WONDER DAILY

How a Zipper Holds Shut and Comes Apart

A jacket zipper

Above the slider the two sides of a zipper are joined. Below it they hang apart. Each small part has its own job.

Tape, teeth, slider

A zipper has three main parts: the cloth tape, the rows of teeth fixed on it, and the slider that joins or parts the teeth.

Teeth that mesh

Each tooth has a bump and a hollow. The slider squeezes the rows together, so each bump tucks into the next hollow.

A hidden lock

When the pull-tab lies flat, a tiny piece slips between two teeth and holds the slider still. Lifting the tab frees it.

Pin into box

A jacket zipper comes apart. Its thin pin goes fully into a small box, so both rows start lined up for the slider.

Stops at the ends

A stop at each end keeps the slider from running off the teeth. On a jacket, the box is the stop at the bottom.

Make a little book

1 Fold it into 8 boxes. Open it flat.

2 Fold short end to short end. Cut the thick line. Open it.

3 Fold the long way, pictures out. Push the ends in.

4 Fold into a book. Page 1 goes on the front!